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Communication

Absence of Relative Clause Islands in Adara

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Abstract

I argue that definite relative clauses, despite their stable strong island status cross-linguistically, lack island status in Adara. The structure is neither selective nor weak, but rather completely permeable, allowing the free extraction of both arguments and adjuncts. In support of the claim that A-bar movement may escape relative clause domains in Adara, I adduce evidence from crossover effects, reconstruction effects, and quantifier float. In addition, I show that relative clause-internal material may probe upwards and outwards, triggering long-distance agreement of relativized verbs with clause-external subjects in a way that is not possible with true island structures in the language.

Keywords: island escape; A-bar movement; relative clauses; long-distance agreement; Adara

1. Introduction

This article reports on the absence of relative clause (RC) islands in the Ekhwa variety of Adara (EA[1]) (ISO 639-3 [KAD]), an under-documented Benue-Congo language spoken by approximately 300,000 (Hon et al., 2018) to 500,000 people (Simons & Fennig, 2018) in Nigeria. A-bar dependency formation across both subject and object-modifying RCs is possible in the language, as illustrated below. Examples (1a,b) show that *wh-* fronting from the direct object position of an object-modifying RC is attested in the language. The datum in (1c) establishes that *wh-* expressions may also be extracted from the direct object position of subject-modifying RCs. Adjunct *wh-* expressions may freely extract from these environments as well.

(1) a.

iwé	ŋu	i	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da	ku	da	___	]
who	FOC	1.SG	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	touch		

'Who is the x such that I saw the person that touched x?'

b.

ocɪná	otákàdá	ko	o	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da
which	book	FOC	2.SG	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP
i	ku	dʒe	___]				
1.SG	PRF	give					

'Which book is the x such that you saw the person that I gave x?'

c.

iwé	ŋu	[anú-ǹ	da	ku	da	___]	ku	ɹɔ́	egbé
who	FOC	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	touch		PRF	buy	house

'Who is the x such that the person that touched x bought a house?'

The facts in (1) are notable in light of the cross-linguistic tendency for complex NPs to constrain A-bar dependency formation. Other complex NPs in the language behave as expected with respect to constraints on A-bar movement. The data in (2) show that

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neither subjects (2a) nor direct objects (2b) may be extracted from clausal complements of definite nouns.

(2) a. *iwé ŋu omúsé kpéɹi ɔnʃó-ŋ [da ___ ku ɹɔ́ egbé]
who FOC Omuse know song-DEF.INAN COMP PRF buy house
Intended: 'Who is the x such that Omuse knows the song that x bought a house?'

b. *ɪncí mo omúsé kpéɹi ɔnʃó-ŋ [da ijâ ku ɹɔ́ ___]
what FOC[2] Omuse know song-DEF.INAN COMP Ija PRF buy
Intended: 'What is the x such that Omuse knows the song that Ija bought x?'

The facts in (1) are additionally notable in the context of other well-known strong island constraints. Domains that hinder A-bar movement cross-linguistically also block the formation of A-bar dependencies in EA. Extraction from sentential subjects (3a), reason clausal adjuncts (3b), and conditional clauses (3c) is systematically barred. RCs in the language, therefore, are unique. Unlike other expected island domains, escape from RC "islands" is possible.

(3) a. *ɪncí mo [ai i ku ɹɔ́ ___] ku nɛ omúsé na
what FOC COMP .SG PRF buy PRF make Omuse SBJV
go oʃɔ́
hear anger
Intended: 'What is the x such that that I bought x made Omuse angry?'

b. *ɪncí mo i sù kɹɔ́ [sɛbɪ́lí da omúsé ku ɹɔ́ ___]
what FOC 1.SG PROG cry because COMP Omuse PRF buy
Intended: 'What is the x such that I am crying because Omuse bought x?'

c. *ɪncí mo [omúsé ba ɹɔ́ ___], ijâ sú kɹɔ́
what FOC Omuse COND buy Ija FUT cry
Intended: 'What is the x such that if Omuse buys x, Ija will cry?'

Although surprising from a universalist Generative perspective on islands and constraints on movement, the A-bar transparency of RCs in EA is not surprising from an Africanist perspective. Schurr et al. (2024) demonstrate that RCs in Shupamem are fully transparent for the formation of A-bar dependencies.[2] Nominal constituents (though not VP or PP constituents) may freely extract from RCs in Limbum (Hein, 2024). Korsah and Murphy (2024) show that RCs in Akan lack island status. Smith (2024) establishes that subject-modifying RCs in Mende (though not object-modifying RCs in the language) allow for the A-bar extraction of RC-internal material. Ekhwa Adara therefore represents yet another African language in which "island" escape is possible.

The data in (1) appear to show that escape from RC structures in the language is possible. In Section 2, I adduce evidence from crossover effects, reconstruction effects, and quantifier float that the *wh-* dependencies presented in (1) are the result of movement. In Section 3, I show that RC-internal material may probe upwards and outwards, triggering agreement of RC-internal verbs with clause-external subjects in a way that is not possible with the true island structures in (2) and (3). Section 4 concludes the article.

2. Escape from RCs

Bawa (2025) presents several arguments that the derivations underpinning *wh-* ex situ in EA are the result of movement and not base-generation. Among his arguments are the observations that ex situ *wh-* structures: show sensitivity to crossover effects, manifest reconstruction effects, feed quantifier float, and license parasitic gaps. In this section, I will deploy some of these movement diagnostics to support the claim that A-bar escape from RCs is possible in the language.

2.1. Sensitivity to Crossover Effects

Ex situ *wh-* expressions connected to RC-internal positions must be interpreted as disjoint in reference from matrix pronominal subjects.

(4)	iwé	ŋu	a	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da	ku	da	___]
	who	FOC	3.SG	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	touch	

‘Who$_i$ is the x such that he/she$_{j/*i}$ saw the person that touched x?’

Given that the matrix pronominal subjects c-command the *wh-* gaps in (4), the impossibility of pronominal binding in structures such as these may be plausibly attributed to a strong crossover effect—an A-bar moved element cannot move across a c-commanding pronoun that it ends up binding.

We find a similar effect with non-c-commanding pronouns in subject position. Peripheral *wh-* expressions linked to positions within RCs may not receive interpretations in which they corefer with pronouns embedded inside the subject constituent.

(5)	iwé	ŋu	awɛ̂n-ŋ	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da	ku	da	___]
	who	FOC	child-3.SG	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	touch	

‘Who$_i$ is the x such that his/her$_{j/*i}$ child saw the person that touched x?’

Given that the possessive pronominals fail to c-command the *wh-* gaps in (5), the impossibility of pronominal binding in structures like these can be attributed to a weak crossover effect—an A-bar moved element cannot move across a non-c-commanding pronoun that it ends up binding.

The crossover data in (4) and (5) involve matrix pronominal expressions, and while *suggestive* of escape from RCs, they are only sufficient to diagnose *wh-* movement in the main clause. To complete the argument for RC escape from crossover effects, we observe that pronominals in embedded subject positions also trigger crossover effects with *wh-* expressions originating inside RCs. The data in (6) present these facts. (6a) illustrates a strong crossover effect, while (6b) shows a weak crossover effect.

(6)	a.	iwé	ŋu	í	ku	ɹi	[otákàdá-ŋ	da	a	ku	
		who	FOC	1.SG	PRF	see	book-DEF.INAN	COMP	3.SG	PRF	
		dʒe	___]								
		give									

‘Who$_i$ is the x such that I saw the book that he/she$_{j/*i}$ gave to x?’

b.	iwé	ŋu	í	ku	ɹi	[otákàdá-ŋ	da	awɛ̂n-ŋ	ku
	who	FOC	1.SG	PRF	see	book-DEF.INAN	COMP	child-3.SG	PRF
	dʒe	___]							
	give								

‘Who$_i$ is the x such that I saw the book that his/her$_{j/*i}$ child gave to x?’

Together, the interpretative asymmetries in these examples support the claim that the peripheral *wh-* occurrences have indeed escaped the RCs.

2.2. Reconstruction Effects

Peripheral *wh-* phrases connected to RC-internal positions behave as though they occupy those RC-internal positions with respect to binding theoretic interpretative considerations such as Condition C (7a) and Condition A (7b).

(7) a.

ocɪná	otákàdá	a	mo	ɛbei	omúsé	ko	a	mani
which	book	3.SG	has	matters	Omuse	FOC	3.SG	teach
[anú-ǹ	da	ku	ɹɔ	___]				
person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	buy					

'Which book about Omuse$_i$ is the x such that he$_{j/*i}$ taught the person that bought x?'

b.

ocɪná	otákàdá	a	mo	ɛbei	icʷí-ŋ	ko	omúsé	mani
which	book	3.SG	has	matters	head-3.SG	FOC	Omuse	teach
[anú-ǹ	da	ku	ɹɔ	___]				
person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	buy					

'Which book about himself$_i$ is the x such that Omuse$_i$ taught the person that bought x?'

The expression *Omúsé*, which is embedded inside the peripheral complex *wh-* phrase in (7a), is unable to corefer with the matrix third person singular pronominal subject despite a lack of surface c-command between the two expressions. These facts are consistent with an analysis in which the complex *wh-* expression is interpreted inside the RC. In such a position, the inability of *Omúsé* to corefer with the matrix pronominal subject could be attributed to a violation of Condition C of the binding theory. Thus, the Condition C-based reconstruction effect in (7a) implicates an analysis in which the complex ex situ *wh-* phrase has evacuated the RC. In (7b), we find a comparable situation involving a complex ex situ *wh-* phrase that contains the reflexive expression *icʷí-ŋ*. Despite the fact that the antecedent of the reflexive (*Omúsé*) fails to c-command it on the surface, the anaphor respects Condition A of the binding theory and is therefore licensed. This suggests an analysis in which the expression 'which book about himself' is interpreted inside the RC despite its surface position in the left periphery, once again supporting the conclusion that the complex *wh-* phrase has escaped the RC.

The reconstruction effects in (7) all involve matrix antecedents and are therefore sufficient to diagnose whether the *wh-* expressions have moved in the main clause. It is important to also consider cases of reconstruction involving antecedents occupying RC-internal positions, for such cases would implicate movement out of the embedded domain.[3] Consider the following data.

(8) a.

ocɪná	otákàdá	a	mo	ɛbei	omúsé	ko	í	ku	ɹi
which	book	3.SG	has	matters	Omuse	FOC	1.SG	PRF	see
[anú-ǹ	da	a	ku	dʒe	___]				
person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	3.SG	PRF	give					

'Which book about Omuse$_i$ is the x such that I saw the person that he$_{j/*i}$ gave x?'

b.

ocɪná	otákàdá	a	mo	ɛbei	icʷí-ŋ	ko	í	ku	ɹi
which	book	3.SG	has	matters	head-3.SG	FOC	1.SG	PRF	see
[anú-ǹ	da	omúsé	ku	dʒe	___]				
person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	Omuse	PRF	give					

'Which book about himself$_i$ is the x such that I saw the person that Omuse$_i$ gave x?'

Example (8a) instantiates another Condition C-based reconstruction effect, while (8b) represents another Condition A reconstruction effect. When paired with the data in (7), these facts once again support the claim that escape from RCs is possible in EA.

2.3. Quantifier Float

Additional evidence for A-bar escape from RCs in EA comes from quantifier float data.[4] Quantifier float refers to configurations in which a quantifier is construed with its associate despite a non-local (non-adjacent) relationship between them. Under the assumption that quantified expressions are licensed syntactically, *wh-* quantifier float structures are expected to be impossible when the associate vacates an island, as in French (Baunaz,

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2008) and Irish English (McCloskey, 2000), among other languages. In EA, floating quantifiers associated with left peripheral *wh*- expressions may be found RC-internally (9b), strongly suggesting that RC domains do not have the status of islands in the language. Structures like (9b) yield the same interpretations as when the quantifier and its associate appear together in a left peripheral position (as in (9a)).

(9) a.

ɪncí	áwáŋ	ko	omúsé	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da	ku
what	all	FOC	Omuse	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF
ɹɔ	___]							
buy								

‘What all is the x such that Omuse saw the person that bought x?’

b.

ɪncí	ko	omúsé	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da	ku
what	FOC	Omuse	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF
ɹɔ	___	áwáŋ]					
buy		all					

‘What all is the x such that Omuse saw the person that bought x?’

This contrasts sharply with the distribution of floating quantifiers inside clausal complements of definite nouns in the language, which have the status of islands in EA (see (2)). In these structures, quantifier float is systematically unavailable (10b), as is consistent with their status as islands.

(10) a.

*ɪncí	áwáŋ	ko	omúsé	kpéɹi	ɔnʃó-ŋ	[da	ijâ
what	all	FOC	Omuse	know	song-DEF.INAN	COMP	Ija
ku	ɹɔ́ ___]						
PRF	buy						

Intended: ‘What all is the x such that Omuse knows the song that Ija bought x?’

b.

*ɪncí	ko	omúsé	kpéɹi	ɔnʃó-ŋ	[da	ijâ
what	FOC	Omuse	know	song-DEF.INAN	COMP	Ija
ku	ɹɔ́	___	áwáŋ]			
PRF	buy		all			

Intended: ‘What all is the x such that Omuse knows the song that Ija bought x?’

3. Agreement

The data in Section 2 reveal that A-bar dependency formation across RC boundaries is possible in EA. In this section, I show that another type of dependency formation across RC domains is possible in the language, namely, long-distance subject–verb agreement. Taken together, the facts show that outward-looking grammatical operations are not constrained by RC structures in the language, which is consistent with the claim that RCs do not have island status in EA. Section 3.1 introduces the phenomenon of subject agreement in EA, and Section 3.2 considers its application across a variety of island boundaries in the language.

3.1. Subject–Verb Agreement

Verbs in EA may optionally agree with subjects.[5] Agreeing elements appear as verbal suffixes and are formally identical to the accusative pronoun series.[6] There is no interpretive consequence of subject–verb agreement in the language. The data in (11) illustrate the phenomenon. Note that the 1.PL agreement marker (11d) is syncretic with the 3.PL form (11f).

(11) a. í ku tíná(-i) i-sabá
1.SG PRF cook-1.SG CL-rice
'I cooked rice.'

b. o ku tíná(-o) i-sabá
2.SG PRF cook-2.SG CL-rice
'You cooked rice.'

c. a ku tíná(-ŋ) i-sabá
3.SG PRF cook-3.SG CL-rice
'He/she cooked rice.'

d. andě ku tíná(-má) i-sabá
1.PL PRF cook-1.PL CL-rice
'We cooked rice.'

e. ɲi ku tíná(-ɲi) i-sabá
2.PL PRF cook-2.PL CL-rice
'Y'all cooked rice.'

f. á ku tíná(-má) i-sabá
3.PL PRF cook-3.PL CL-rice
They cooked rice.'

In embedded contexts, verbs may optionally agree with local subjects, or they may enter into long-distance agreement relationships with higher subjects. The data in (12) illustrate this phenomenon.

(12) a. i ku ga(-i) ai omúsé ku ɹɔ́(-ŋ/-i) egbé
1.SG PRF say-1.SG COMP Omuse PRF buy-3.SG/1.SG house
'I said that Omuse bought a house.'

b. o ku ga(-o) ai omúsé kpéɹi(-ŋ/-o) ai i ku ɹɔ́(-i/-ŋ/-o) egbé
2.SG PRF say-2.SG COMP Omuse know-3.SG/2.SG COMP 1.SG PRF buy-1.SG/3.SG/2.SG house
'You said that Omuse knows that I bought a house.'

When an embedded verb agrees with a local subject, a special intonation (greater intensity/amplitude on the subject, though no tone change) is required. No special intonation is required when a verb agrees with a non-local subject. Once again, there is no interpretative or pragmatic consequence of subject–verb agreement, regardless of whether it is local or long-distance.

3.2. Agreement Across Island Boundaries

Despite the availability of subject agreement across clause boundaries (12), verbs embedded in islands may not agree with island-external subjects. In these configurations, only local agreement is (optionally) possible. The data in (13) illustrate. Subject marking on the matrix verb, while possible, is omitted in this example set for readability.

(13) a.

i	kpéɹi	ɔnʃó-ŋ	[da	ijâ	ku	ɹɔ́(-ŋ/*-i)	egbé]
1.SG	know	song-DEF.INAN	COMP	Ija	PRF	buy-3.SG/1.SG	house

‘I know the song that Ija bought a house.’

b.

[ai	o	ku	ɹɔ́(-o/*-ŋ)	egbé]	ku	nɛ	ijâ	na
COMP	2.SG	PRF	buy-2.SG/3.SG	house	PRF	make	Ija	SBJV
go	oʃɔ́							
hear	anger							

‘That you bought a house made Ija angry.’

c.

a	sù	kɹɔ́	[sɛbɪ̂lí	da	á	ku	ɹɔ́(-má/*-ŋ)	egbé]
3.SG	PROG	cry	because	COMP	3.PL	PRF	buy-3.PL/3.SG	house

‘He/she is crying because they bought a house.’

d.

[ɲi	ba	ɹɔ́(-ɲi/*-ŋ)	egbé]	ijâ	sú	kɹɔ́
2.PL	COND	buy-2.PL/3.SG	house	Ija	FUT	cry

‘If y’all buy a house, Ija will cry.’

The datum in (13a) shows that subject agreement out of clausal complements of definite nouns is not possible in EA. Example (13b) illustrates that verbs embedded in sentential subjects may not agree with outside subjects either. (13c) reveals that agreement with subjects external to reason clauses is not allowed, while (13d) shows that verbs embedded in conditional clauses may not agree with non-local subjects. These facts support the conclusion that clausal complements of definite nouns, sentential subjects, and adjunct clauses (i.e., so-called strong islands) are not only islands for A-bar dependency formation but also for long-distance agreement relations. That is, agreement cannot ignore island boundaries in EA. Similar facts concerning islands and agreement (albeit cases where the agreement controller is *inside* the island and agreement is blocked) have been pointed out by Polinsky and Potsdam (2001), Bruening (2001), Branigan and MacKenzie (2002), Bobaljik and Wurmbrand (2005), Bhatt (2005) and Keine (2013), among others.

We observe an agreement asymmetry when it comes to RC structures in the language. Unlike the island configurations presented in (13), both local and non-local subject agreement is possible for RC-internal verbs. The facts in (14) demonstrate this phenomenon.

(14) a.

i	ku	ɹi	[anú-ǹ	da	ku	da(-ŋ/-i)	ijâ]
1.SG	PRF	see	person-DEF.ANIM	COMP	PRF	touch-3.SG/1.SG	Ija

‘I saw the person that touched Ija.’

b.

omúsé	sú	ɟeni	ijâ	[ɪgbɛ́ɹɛ̀-ŋ	da	o	ku
Omuse	FUT	show	Ija	basket-DEF.INAN	COMP	2.SG	PRF
ɹɔ́(-o/-ŋ)]							
buy-2.SG/3.SG							

‘Omuse will show Ija the basket that you bought.’

Example (14a) shows that in subject RCs in object position, agreement with the matrix subject is possible, as is agreement with the local embedded subject. (14b) establishes that the same agreement pattern is possible in object RCs. These facts are striking. In languages where RCs constitute strong islands, RC-internal probes fail to agree with island-external agreement controllers (Bobaljik & Wurmbrand, 2005; Bošković, 2007; Heck & Cuartero, 2012; Douglas, 2015; and Deal, 2016, among others). The robust availability of agreement out of RCs in EA speaks to the porous nature of relative clause structures in the language.

Returning to those instances of successful *wh*- movement out of RCs discussed at the outset of Article (1), we find that here too the relativized verb may undergo long-distance agreement with the matrix subject.

(15) a. iwé ŋu i ku ɹi [anú-ǹ da ku
who FOC 1.SG PRF see person-DEF.ANIM COMP PRF
da(-ŋ/-i) ___]
touch-3.SG/1.SG
'Who is the x such that I saw the person that touched x?'

b. ocɪná otákàdá ko o ku ɹi anú-ǹ da
which book FOC 2.SG PRF see person-DEF.ANIM COMP
i ku dʒe(-i/-o) ___]
1.SG PRF give-1.SG/2.SG
'Which book is the x such that you saw the person that I gave x?

These agreement facts, coupled with the extraction facts previously considered in Section 2, are consistent with the conclusion that RCs in EA are fully porous domains for the formation of long-distance dependencies.

4. Conclusions

In this article, I argued that definite relative clauses, despite their stable strong island status cross-linguistically, lack island status in Ekhwa Adara. RCs in the language are neither selective nor weak, but rather completely permeable, allowing the free extraction of both arguments and adjuncts. In support of the claim that A-bar movement may escape relative clause domains in EA, I presented evidence from crossover effects, reconstruction effects, and quantifier float. In addition, I showed that relative clause-internal material may probe upwards and outwards, triggering long-distance agreement of relativized verbs with clause-external subjects in a way that is not possible with true island structures in the language. We thus observe two distinct types of escape from RCs in EA.

At present, it is not clear what structurally distinguishes RCs from those domains that constitute true islands in the language or why Adara RCs lack island status. I leave the exploration of this issue to future research, pointing out that Schurr's (2026) work on the absence of clausal islands in Shupamem may offer valuable clues and insights.

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Abbreviations

The following abbreviations are used in this manuscript:

ANIM	Animate
CL	Class marker
COMP	Complementizer
COND	Conditional
DEF	Definite
FOC	Focus
FUT	Future

INAN	Inanimate
PRF	Perfect
PL	Plural
PROG	Progressive
SG	Singular
SBJV	Subjunctive

Notes

1. The data and judgments presented in this paper come exclusively from fieldwork in the context of two Field Methods classes taught at University X in Fall 2022 and Fall 2023. Data are presented in IPA. Abbreviations for glosses follow the Leipzig Glossing Rules. The following diacritics are used to mark surface tone: v́ = high, v̀ = low, v = mid; v̂ = falling; v̌ = rising.
2. See also Kandybowicz and Nchare (2023) for evidence that both restrictive and non-restrictive RCs in Shupamem permit extraction (topicalization).
3. Thanks to a thoughtful reviewer for making this point.
4. Floating quantifiers have been argued by some authors (e.g., Déprez, 1989) to be a property of A, but not A-bar movement. Since the floating quantifiers examined in this section associate with *wh-* expressions, I assume that they are sufficient to diagnose A-bar movement, as in McCloskey (2000).
5. Although agreement with the subject is optional in most cases, there are contexts in which agreement is obligatory. One case concerns select causative–inchoative alternations. When certain transitive/causative verbs like 'break', 'cook', or 'spill' are used intransitively, subject agreement on the verb becomes mandatory. This pattern, however, is limited to a subset of verbs in the language that participate in the causative–inchoative alternation. For example, although 'grow' can be used causatively, subject agreement on the verb is not obligatory when 'grow' is used inchoatively. Further investigation into this phenomenon is clearly warranted.
6. A reviewer asks whether the morphemes I am calling agreement markers are more accurately subject clitics, given the identity between these markers and pronouns. Although this issue certainly warrants careful examination in future work, there are three reasons I analyze them as agreement markers. One, unlike clitics, the markers are for the most part (though see note 6) completely optional. Two, while clitics can sometimes be separated from their hosts, the markers in question occupy a fixed position—obligatorily right adjacent to the verb. Third, although many of the markers are in fact formally similar to pronouns, not all are (i.e., 3.SG and 1.PL/3.PL).

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